

10

cultural black spots

From the muzzling of the press by an elected autocrat to the death of a theatre activist at the hands of political goons, India has had its list of excesses

2 Pressed Down Media Censorship During the Emergency

"Who's afraid of the Emergency?" proclaimed INDIA TODAY in December 1975. Well, at that time, every media house was. The 21-month period between June 1975 to March 1977, when Indira Gandhi confused democracy with dictatorship, saw bans and checks imposed on the media and the arts. India responded to her autocracy by throwing her out of power in 1977.



AP PHOTO/KHALID TANVEER

3 Reading Too Much Fatwa against Rushdie

The penning of *Satanic Verses* by Salman Rushdie saw a fatwa being issued by Iran's late cleric Ayatollah Khomeini for its "irreverent depiction" of Prophet Mohammed. Rushdie's own country was one of the first to ban the book that was "hardly read, or read and hardly understood" (INDIA TODAY, March 1989).

1 Dark Shadow Vijay Tendulkar Under Attack

Vijay Tendulkar, who told INDIA TODAY in June 1980 that "he was branded as a playwright who wrote plays no one understood", often got into trouble due to his habit of speaking his mind. During the 1970s, this icon of Marathi literature was constantly targeted by the Shiv Sena for depicting its rise in a poor light. One of his plays *Sakharam Binder* came as a bit of a shock because of the swear words that peppered the dialogues. Then, the censors objected to the depiction of forced abortion through a blood-stained sari in his play *Gidhaade*. The stain had to be changed to black, marking the moment as a cultural black spot.



PRAMOD PUSKARNA

4 The Curtain Falls Safdar Hashmi's Death

His was the voice of the masses. And then it was silenced, forever. On January 1, 1989, while performing a street play *Halla Bol* near Delhi, Safdar Hashmi was fatally attacked by a group of Congress party goons. His killers could be convicted only 10 years later. But in his death, he "not only turned attention to increasingly unabashed political violence" (INDIA TODAY, January 1989), but also to the threat to freedom of expression.

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THE THREAT TO FREEDOM OF EXPRESSION